



KEY
The world's five largest garbage dumps, or landfills, labeled with the amount of waste dumped in them every day.

Puente Hills—Los Angeles, California
Approximately 11,350 tons per day.

Apex—Las Vegas, Nevada
Approximately 11,600 tons per day.

Greenland
Currently Greenland produces 30% more waste than it can process, though two new garbage-to-energy incinerators are due to open in 2021 and 2022.

Western Pacific Garbage Patch
A lot of discarded litter ends up in rivers, which take it to the sea, where circular currents called gyres collect it into vast patches in the ocean surface waters. This patch is the largest of these oceanic rubbish dumps.

North Atlantic Garbage Patch
The North Atlantic Garbage Patch measures hundreds of miles across. It shifts by as much as 990 miles (1,600 km) north and south with the seasons.

Bordo Poniente Landfill—Nezahualcoyotl, Mexico
Over 13,200 tons per day.

Gabon
Less wealthy countries, such as Gabon, produce less garbage because people buy less overall, they buy proportionally more local produce without plastic packaging, and do more recycling.

South Pacific Garbage Patch
So far, the South Pacific Gyre appears to contain less plastic waste than other ocean garbage patches.

South Atlantic Garbage Patch
The first evidence of a South Atlantic Garbage Patch was discovered in 2011. Most plastic particles in ocean garbage patches are too small to be seen with the naked eye.

Garbage and waste

As living standards improve worldwide and cities grow, so does the amount of garbage that people produce. Most waste goes to garbage dumps, which are expensive, use up a lot of land, and are harmful to the environment. Recycling is one way of helping to stop the global garbage heap from growing any bigger.

Top of the recycling table
Only a handful of countries currently recycle more than half their waste; Germany tops this list, recycling 56.1% of all waste in 2019. This figure is a rapid increase from 1991, when the country

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Only a handful of countries currently recycle more than half their waste; Germany tops this list, recycling 56.1% of all waste in 2019. This figure is a rapid increase from 1991, when the country recycled only 3% of its garbage.

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